

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 113

Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1974-1976

Coverage Date: 1974-1976

Place Coverage

Morongo (a pseudonym), Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): II

Her face was flushed as she watched her son drink from his bottle on her lap. I tried to mollify her by saying that abroad women can go to a clinic and have a pregnancy test to confirm their suspicions, but here it is different. You have to wait and see. I said repeatedly that I had not meant to upset her. I thought we could joke together as women who stand in a certain relationship with one another can speak of things they would not mention to others. We joke about so many things, about sex and our husbands. I had believed we could joke about pregnancy also. But I had been mistaken, and I was very sorry. She replied, in essence, that she was afraid if she told us she was pregnant, Mary would spread the rumor around that she was *boasting* of her good fortune. In addition, women in the neighborhood were always asking, "Why does Sarah go to your house and not to ours?" and she would reply that she did not know. She said, "They are jealous that you are my friend and not theirs." There were plenty of women nearby who were jealous of her for one reason or another and who would eagerly seize on an excuse to accuse her of boasting.

123
[Observation In Research](#)

152
[Drives And Emotions](#)

159
[Life History Materials](#)

828
[Ethnopsychology](#)

843
[Pregnancy](#)

I tried to explain my reasons for coming to see her. To deny that there was a possibility that "other women" (I presumed she meant her sister-in-law Sabera in particular) might be jealous of her friendship with me would be pointless, since I imagined this was true. So I told her why I had chosen to get to know her better than her neighbors. I [114](#) said that I studied mothers and little children, but I could not know everyone equally well or visit them equally often. I had to choose a few. I liked her, and she had seemed happy to see me when I was first going about the neighborhood. Some women were dour or too busy to talk to me, but she had welcomed me. That is why I had continued to come so often. Trufena listened and seemed reassured. When we got up to leave, she begged us to stay longer, which we did, and then she escorted us a long way along the path, something she had not done before. However, she offered us no refreshment, which she certainly could have done, since Ombui was on leave and had brought her tea and sugar as well as money.

123
[Observation In Research](#)

159
[Life History Materials](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)